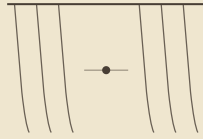

A READING EDITION



Six Characters *in Search of an Author*

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

• • •

A COMEDY IN THE MAKING

Luigi Pirandello

translated by Edward Storer

DIRECTOR'S COPY • KIARASH JAMISHIDI

Published 1921 • eBook No. 0608521h

—

DRAMATIS PERSONÆ

for an eight-performer staging across three stripped settings, with two stage objects and three brief projections

The Six Characters

THE FATHER

THE MOTHER

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

THE SON

THE BOY

silent — coat and chair

THE CHILD

silent — wrapped bundle

MADAME PACE

embodied by Player 3

The Village Players — Lausanne

THE MANAGER

PLAYER 1

Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor

PLAYER 2

Leading Lady · Property Man · Fourth Actor · Second Lady Lead

PLAYER 3

Juvenile Lead · Prompter · Madame Pace · An Actor · Fifth Actor

P O R T R A I T S

the bodies, the natures, and the playing of them

What follows is the director's gallery of the people who will walk into Act One — a body for each, a nature for each, and a note to the company on how to play them. Pirandello supplied the bodies; the readings beside them are the work of K. J., and are offered as starting points, not as commands.

The Father

THE BRAIN OF THE FAMILY

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

The Mother

S I L E N C E T H A T F I N A L L Y S C R E A M S

A woman in modest black under a heavy widow's veil; beneath it, when she lifts it, a face the colour of wax. Crushed and terrified, as if pressed down by a weight too great to name. Silent for most of Act One — then, in Act Two, her presence becomes a sound, the only true unmediated cry in the play. Stillness is her language. Her line *It's taking place now. It happens all the time* should land like a stone learning to speak. Do not make her sympathetic in the easy way. She is heavier than that.

The Step-Daughter

S P E E D A N D S H A M E T U R N E D O U T W A R D

Dashing, almost impudent, beautiful — in elegant mourning, black worn with style. Speed, shame turned outward, revenge wearing the dress of truth. She knows men look at her and uses the knowing; sex is her oldest weapon and her oldest wound, and she does not pretend either. Never apologetic — the performance is propulsion. Vulgar where vulgarity is the truth, arrogant where arrogance is armour. Her tenderness for the Child — for the bundle — must be unbearably real, so that her contempt for the Boy reads as the same wound, pointed in the opposite direction. She has a single projected moment in Act Two — the only audible projection in the production — where she speaks to her silent siblings as real children: tender to the Child, then violent with the Boy when she finds the revolver in his pocket. Below the screen, her live body stands silent, listening to her own recorded voice. The Father she neither pities nor forgives; she has not finished punishing him.

The Son

THE ONE WHO WILL NOT ACT

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing. His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. Make it count.

The Boy

SILENT — A BLACK COAT ON A CHAIR

A silent fourteen-year-old in black — in this production, a black coat with a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a small leather satchel by the chair leg. The chair sits at the edge of the stage. The other Characters speak to the chair as if to him. He is shown three times in projection, briefly each time: in the entrance video at the start of Act One, walking to the chair and leaving his coat on it; in the Step-Daughter's monologue at the start of Act Two, when she seizes him and finds the revolver in his pocket; and at the fountain in Act Three, a single held shot, ten seconds, then darkness. Everywhere else, the chair is everywhere he is. In Act Three the chair is moved behind the fountain basin; the gunshot is heard, not seen.

The Child

S I L E N T — A W R A P P E D W H I T E B U N D L E

A silent four-year-old in white, with a black silk sash — in this production, a small bundle of white cloth, like a swaddling, carried and kissed and set down and lifted again by the Step-Daughter and the Mother. The bundle is silent and motionless; it is moved only by other hands. The audience reads it as the bundle because the Step-Daughter does. She is shown twice in projection, briefly: in the entrance video at the start of Act One, where the Step-Daughter sets her down beside her and she becomes the bundle; and in the Step-Daughter's monologue at the start of Act Two, where she is addressed tenderly as a real child. The drowning is never shown — told by the Son, hidden by the Step-Daughter bending over the bundle at the fountain. The rest is sound and silence.

The Manager

T H E D I R E C T O R O N A D E A D L I N E

Whatever an exhausted, competent theatre director at the end of a difficult week looks like — the schedule burning, faintly contemptuous of the playwright he has been forced to stage, faintly proud of his company. Pragmatic, cynical, slightly ridiculous, slightly brave. He treats the play in front of him as a job, until the job turns into something he does not have a name for, and then he tries to make a play out of it anyway. He is wrong in tone almost constantly, and right in instinct almost as often. Do not play him as a fool. Give him compassion. He is everyone in the audience who has ever been forced to make sense of someone else's grief on a deadline.

Player 1

THE MAN WITH ALL THE HATS

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. The Leading Man's vanity is his spine in Act One: the cook's-cap argument with the Manager, the strut, the offence at being asked to wear a chef's hat in a serious play. The Door-keeper is small, apologetic, and lets the wrong six people in. The Machinist is the one who drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two. Every transition between roles must be visible to the audience — the hat-toss, the change of bearing, the lift of the chin. Lean into the Leading Man early. The contrast with everything else will land harder later.

Player 2

THE DIVA AND THE PROPS

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. The Leading Lady is offended at being made to play the Step-Daughter, and offended again when the Step-Daughter laughs at her attempt. The Property Man is the working theatre itself — the table, the folding screen, the pegs, the patience the director has personally exhausted. Two opposite registers in the same body: the vanity that costs nothing, and the labour that costs everything. Let the audience see her flip between them in the same scene. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory.

Player 3

THE YOUNGEST, AND MADAME PACE

Carries the Juvenile Lead, the Prompter, Madame Pace, An Actor, and the Fifth Actor. The Juvenile Lead is eager and slightly ridiculous. The Prompter is in his box, sometimes a court stenographer, sometimes complaining about the draught. Then comes the production's most theatrically demanding moment: Madame Pace, an Italian-Swiss immigrant who runs an atelier off the rue de Bourg in Lausanne, an apparition summoned by the very arrangement of the stage — hats on pegs, a shop window with the sign *robes et manteaux*, a folding screen. Player 3 enters her costume the way an apparition enters a body — fat, bleach-blonde, rouged, dressed in comical black silk with a long silver chain at her waist ending in a pair of scissors. Half Italian, half French, ridiculous and grotesque. Play the comedy of her dialect at full strength; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength too. The audience laughs, and is then disgusted with itself for having laughed — that double sensation is the point of her.

DAYTIME · THE STAGE OF A THEATRE

The Comedy is without acts or scenes. The performance is interrupted once, without the curtain being lowered, when the manager and the chief characters withdraw to arrange the scenario. A second interruption of the action takes place when, by mistake, the stage hands let the curtain down.

A NOTE ON THIS PRODUCTION

How this version is to be performed

This edition adapts Pirandello's play for a chamber staging of **eight live performers, two stage objects, three brief projections, across three stripped, sculptural settings**. Every line of the Storer translation is preserved. Only the *who-plays-what* is rearranged.

EIGHT BODIES ON THE STAGE

Four play the family. The Father, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, and The Son are each played by a single actor in flesh, and each remains so for the whole play.

One plays The Manager. Pirandello's director-figure stays exactly as written.

Three play everyone else. The dozen lesser company roles of the Village Players — Leading Man, Leading Lady, Juvenile Lead, L'Ingénue, Property Man, Prompter, Door-keeper, Machinist, the Second Lady Lead, the Third / Fourth / Fifth Actors — are divided among three Players. **Madame Pace**, who is a Character rather than a company actor but who appears only briefly in Act Two by the magic of the stage, is also embodied by Player 3 in costume and wig.

TWO OBJECTS IN PLACE OF TWO BODIES

The Boy (fourteen) and the Child (about four) — the silent youngest of the Six — are not embodied by live performers *and almost never appear on screen*. They are present, instead, as objects on the stage:

- **The Child** is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth — a swaddling, like an infant in a blanket — which the Step-Daughter carries, kisses, sets down, lifts again. The bundle never moves on its own. The other Characters address it as if it were the Child.

- **The Boy** is a black coat and a schoolboy's cap on a wooden chair, with a small leather satchel by the chair leg. The chair sits at the side of the stage and is later moved behind the fountain basin in Act Three. Where Pirandello's text has the Step-Daughter *seizing* the Boy or *pushing* him forward, she handles the chair and the coat. Where she pulls a revolver from his pocket, she pulls it from the coat hanging on the chair.

This is a deliberate refusal. The audience reads the children from the absences left on the stage, exactly as the family does. The bundle and the chair are heavier than performers would be — every gesture toward them lands.

WHERE IT HAPPENS

The production is set in Lausanne, Switzerland — not the Rome that Pirandello half-implied in 1921, but a modern Swiss city of equal civility and equal cruelty. The theatre company on stage is the **Village Players**, a working repertory house in residence at Lausanne. Their season has been forced to include a play they did not choose, by a playwright they do not particularly trust. They are now in technical rehearsal for it on the morning we walk in. Six strangers will walk in too.

Madame Pace's atelier — the back room where the hundred francs changed hands — sits somewhere off the rue de Bourg, in a courtyard near Saint-François. Her shop sign reads *robes et manteaux*, as Pirandello's stage directions already require. She is Italian-Swiss, an immigrant who has built a small business of dressmaking and other less nameable commerce. Her dialect mix — half Italian, half French — is a foreigner's broken speech: ridiculous, grotesque, instantly recognisable to anyone in the Lausanne audience who has been overcharged at any small shop run by a woman who knows more about them than they would like.

The relocation is a directorial choice, not a textual one. Pirandello's dialogue is unchanged. What changes is the room the play imagines itself inside — the air outside its windows, the language overheard from the street, the city the family fled from and the city they are now trapped inside.

The production refuses period-theatre clutter. Each act has a single defining visual element, and almost nothing else. The aesthetic is sculptural, not decorative. Light, levels, and one bold object per act do the rest.

- **Act One — Chairs.** A bare stage with a circle of chairs. Working lights. No flats, no furniture, no props beyond the chairs themselves. The company sits in their chairs and performs boredom. The Manager has his own chair, set apart. When the Six arrive — first in the entrance video, then in the flesh — they too take chairs. The chair-and-coat that is the Boy is one of these chairs, at the edge. The bundle that is the Child sits in the Step-Daughter's lap.
- **Act Two — Two floors.** The stage is built on two levels. The upper platform is the rehearsal stage — where the family's drama is played, where Madame Pace is summoned, where the white parlour is briefly fitted up. The lower floor is everything else: the space outside the performance, where the actors watch, where the Six wait between scenes, where the technical apparatus of the house lives. The vertical separation is the act's whole point. Performing is up. Watching is down. The line between them is the edge of the upper platform, and the play crosses it constantly.
- **Act Three — The fountain.** A single short basin in the middle of an otherwise bare stage. Stone or concrete. The walls of the basin are high enough that nobody — neither audience nor live actors — can see inside it. When the Step-Daughter bends over the fountain to hide the Child, the basin itself does the hiding. The garden around it is empty. No trees, no flats, no painted cardboard. One basin, four live Characters, the chair-and-coat at the side, the empty stage.

THREE PROJECTIONS — BRIEFLY

The rear wall lights up three times in the production, briefly each time. The Boy and Child are seen in the first two; the Boy alone is seen in the third. Otherwise the screen is dark and the children are objects.

- **The Entrance (Act One)** — A silent video. The Six arrive, lit by a tenuous light. The Boy, in the video, walks to a wooden chair at the edge of the stage and sits down, leaving his coat and cap on it. The Step-Daughter sets the Child down beside her, and the Child becomes a wrapped bundle of white cloth. The light fades; the screen goes dark; from here, the play is live.

- **The Step-Daughter's monologue (Act Two opening)** — The only projection with audible dialogue. The Step-Daughter is shown in video addressing the Child as a real four-year-old, then seizing the Boy and finding the revolver. The bundle and the chair-and-coat remain on the live stage, visible in front of the screen; her voice plays from the speakers, not from the live Step-Daughter, who stands silent below. When the projection ends, the Boy and Child are objects again.
- **The Fountain (Act Three)** — A silent held shot, roughly ten seconds. The Boy by the fountain, motionless, watching his drowned sister. The shot is not the death; it is the act of watching. The revolver shot is heard, not seen.

The cue *[Projection begins]* and *[Projection ends]* bracket each of these three moments. Everywhere else, the rear wall is dark and the children live in the audience's reading of a bundle and a chair.

HOW THE THREE PLAYERS DIVIDE THE COMPANY

The division is built on a single rule: *no Player should ever speak as one of their roles in direct dialogue with another of their own roles*. Every adjacency in the play was checked against this rule.

PLAYER 1	<i>Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor</i>
PLAYER 2	<i>Leading Lady · Property Man · Second Lady Lead (silent) · Fourth Actor</i>
PLAYER 3	<i>Juvenile Lead · Prompter · Madame Pace · An Actor · Fifth Actor</i>

The graph admits one unavoidable corner: in the beat of Act Two where Madame Pace materialises, Player 1 must speak briefly as L'Ingénue and as Leading Man within a few moments. The director should handle this with a wig signifier or a brief turn of the body. All other transitions are clean.

Chorus moments — what Pirandello marks as *The Actors*, *Some Actresses*, *Actors and Actresses* — are gathered in this text under **All Three Players** or

Two Players, and may be split between them at the director's discretion.

HOW SPEAKER TAGS LOOK IN THIS EDITION

When a Player speaks one of their assigned roles, the speaker tag in this text reads:

Player 1 (*as Leading Man*). *Excuse me — must I really wear a cook's cap? I trained at the Conservatoire for this.*

The bold word is the performer; the lighter italic in parentheses is the role they are inhabiting in that moment. The four family Characters and The Manager keep their proper names without parentheses, because each is played by only one performer throughout.

— K. J.



ACT THE FIRST

I



PART I OF ACT ONE

The Rehearsal

The curtain rises on a bare stage with a circle of chairs and nothing else. Working lights. No furniture, no flats, no props. The Manager arrives at his theatre to a half-rehearsed company seated in those chairs in various postures of professional boredom. The play they are meant to rehearse this morning is one of Pirandello's own — *Mixing It Up* — which the Manager believes is unstageable, and which his contract has forced him to stage anyway. He bickers with the Leading Man about being asked to wear a cook's cap in a serious play. He insults the playwright. He insults the script. He insults the conditions under which any working theatre is forced to operate. None of this surprises his actors, who have heard it before; some are tying their shoes, some are reading the paper, none is rehearsing.

The Prompter takes his place in the box, complaining about the draught. The Property Man enters with furniture for an entirely different scene than the one being rehearsed. The Door-keeper waits at the back of the house with a stack of unread letters. The apparatus of the working theatre — irritation, vanity, exhaustion, the small professional dignities — is performing itself, for nobody it knows is watching.

The audience watches all of this comedy and does not yet know it is watching a comedy. The play has not announced itself. We are inside the engine room of the production, not the production. There is no Pirandello here yet, except in the contract burning quietly on the table.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	8 speeches · 355 words
<i>Player 2</i>	3 speeches · 10 words
<i>Player 3</i>	4 speeches · 110 words
<i>Player 1</i>	3 speeches · 33 words
Total	18 speeches · 508 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Manager is the engine of this part. Comic register must be committed — full anti-Pirandello rant, no protective irony.
- Player 1's Leading Man (the cook's-cap argument) is the largest single comic vehicle here. Play the vanity at full pitch.
- The audience should be laughing within three minutes. Pacing is everything; do not slow down for jokes you trust.
- Player 1 is doing three roles in quick succession (Leading Man, L'Ingénue, Door-keeper). Rehearse the transitions until they are physical reflex.
- The Property Man and Door-keeper are small comic anchors. Give them their beats.
- No metaphysics. None. Foreshadowing is a temptation that kills the rest of the evening.
- Work-lights stay up the whole part. Atmospheric lighting changes do not begin until the Six enter.

The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The **ACTORS** and **ACTRESSES** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **PROMPTER** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **PLAYERS**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **MANAGER** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **SECRETARY** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **PROMPTER** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

THE MANAGER *[throwing a letter down on the table]*. I can't see a thing in here. *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* A little light, please — if SSA Lausanne has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)*. Yes sir, yes, at once. *[A light comes down on to the stage.]*

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and try, this time, to play it as if you wanted the public to come back for the third. *[Sits down.] [The ACTORS and ACTRESSES go from the front of the stage to the wings, all except the three who are to begin the rehearsal.]*

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter) [reading the "book"]*. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER *[to PROPERTY MAN]*. Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [noting it down]*. Red set. All right!

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter) [continuing to read from the "book"]*. "Table already laid and writing desk with books and papers. Book-shelves. Exit rear to Leo's bedroom. Exit left to kitchen. Principal exit to right."

THE MANAGER *[energetically]*. Well, you understand: The principal exit over there; here, the kitchen. *[Turning to actor who is to play the part of SOCRATES.]* You make your entrances and exits here. *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* The baize doors at the rear, and curtains.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [noting it down]*. Right!

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter) [reading as before]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, dressed in cook's cap and apron is busy beating an egg in a cup. Philip, also dressed as a cook, is beating another egg. Guido Venanzi is seated and listening."

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [to MANAGER]*. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. I imagine so. It says so there anyway. *[Pointing to the "book."]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. But it's ridiculous! I have a reputation in this canton. Or I had one, before this play.

THE MANAGER *[jumping up in a rage]*. Ridiculous? Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies — Paris seems to be keeping them all for itself — and we are reduced to putting on Pirandello, whom nobody understands, including (I am beginning to suspect) Pirandello himself, who plays the fool with all of us and pockets the royalties from the comfort of the grave? *[The ACTORS grin. The MANAGER goes to LEADING MAN and shouts.]* Yes sir, you put on the cook's cap and beat eggs. Do you suppose that with all this egg-beating business you are on an ordinary stage? Get that out of your head. You represent the shell of the eggs you are beating! *[Laughter and comments among the ACTORS.]* Silence! and listen to my explanations, please! *[To LEADING MAN.]* "The empty form of reason without the fullness of instinct, which is blind." — You stand for reason, your wife is instinct. It's a mixing up of the parts, according to which you who act your own part become the puppet of yourself. Do you understand?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. I'd sooner resign. And I might.

THE MANAGER. Neither do I. But let's get on with it. It's sure to be a glorious failure anyway — and a glorious failure is, in this canton, the closest thing we have to a guarantee. The Swiss will at least be on time to it. *[Confidentially.]* But I say, please face three-quarters. Otherwise — what with the abstruseness of the dialogue, the public that won't be able to hear a word of it, and the critics who will hear far too much — the whole thing will go to hell. And I'll be blamed for all of it. Come on! come on!

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter).* Pardon sir, may I get into my box? There's a bit of a draught — they have not yet fixed the door, you understand — and at my age, sir, in a Lausanne winter, that is how it begins.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, of course!

► PROJECTION BEGINS

The rear wall ignites with a silent video — no dialogue. The Six are shown arriving: the Father and the Mother walking down the aisle, the Step-Daughter and the Son climbing onto the stage with them. A tenuous light surrounds them, almost as if they were lit from inside. The Boy, in the video, walks to a wooden chair at the edge of the stage and sits down; his coat is left on the chair, his cap on the seat, his satchel on the floor. The Step-Daughter, in the video, sets the Child down beside her — and as she does, the Child becomes a small wrapped bundle of white cloth. The light fades. The screen goes dark.

At this point, the DOOR-KEEPER has entered from the stage door and advances towards the manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the Six CHARACTERS enter, and stop by the door at back of stage, so that when the DOOR-KEEPER is about to announce their coming to the MANAGER, they are already on the stage. A tenuous light surrounds them, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

■ PROJECTION ENDS

The screen is dark. The four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — are now on the stage in flesh, having stepped out of the video as if out of a frame. Everything around them is still only chairs: the company in theirs, the Manager in his, the chair-and-coat at the edge. The chair-and-coat is at the edge of the stage where the Boy sat down. The wrapped bundle is in the Step-Daughter's arms where the Child was set down. The tenuous light is gone. From here, the play is live.

He who is known as *THE FATHER* is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.

THE MOTHER seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched chair-and-coat at the edge of the stage — the *BOY* in this production: a wooden chair, a black coat folded over its back, a cap on the seat, a satchel at its foot; on the other hand, she displays a lively tenderness for the small wrapped bundle of white cloth in her arms — *THE CHILD*, with a black silk sash tied around the bundle at the waist.

THE SON (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for *THE FATHER*, supercilious and indifferent to *THE MOTHER*. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.

PART II OF ACT ONE

The Plea

Six figures arrive — on the rear wall, in a silent video. They walk in carrying a strange tenuous light, almost as if lit from inside. In the video the Boy walks to a wooden chair at the edge of the stage and sits down, leaving his coat and cap on the chair. The Step-Daughter sets the Child down beside her, and the Child becomes a small wrapped bundle of white cloth. The light fades. The screen goes dark. The four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — are now on the stage in flesh, having stepped out of the video as if out of a frame.

The Father asks for an author. The Manager, baffled, asks what kind of madmen have walked in off the street. The Step-Daughter taunts the Father and exposes him: a hundred francs in a back-room of a dressmaker's shop, a pale blue envelope on a little table, a transaction this town has agreed not to talk about. The Mother lifts her veil and faints. The Father explains his marriage, the secretary he sent his wife away with, the wet-nurse for his son in the country. Every confession is contradicted by the next mouth that opens. The family is laid bare, and laid bare twice.

The actors of the company, who began this part as bored professionals, slowly recede to the wings. They are now an audience to the spectacle that has walked into their rehearsal. The lighting tightens on the family. The rehearsal room dims around them. By the end of this part, the comic register has burned off and what is left is the family standing inside its own argument, with no author in sight.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>Player 1</i>	5 speeches · 71 words
<i>The Manager</i>	33 speeches · 389 words
<i>The Father</i>	65 speeches · 2,426 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	37 speeches · 1,121 words
<i>Player 3</i>	5 speeches · 34 words
<i>Player 2</i>	4 speeches · 61 words
<i>All Three Players</i>	2 speeches · 11 words
<i>The Mother</i>	20 speeches · 272 words

Total**182 speeches · 4,689 words**

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The transition from comedy to interrogation is the most important pacing decision in Act One. It should be gradual, not signalled.
- The Step-Daughter is the engine of exposure. Her first taunts must land — she is already enjoying the wound she is opening.
- The Mother's faint is the temperature change. The actors-as-audience must visibly register it before the dialogue does.
- The Father's first long speeches should be played as urgent, not eloquent. He is a man fighting to be allowed to exist, not lecturing about it.
- The Son does not move much in this part. His stillness must be a presence, not a passivity.
- Keep the Players visible as they recede to the wings. They are an onstage audience now — they should be doing what audiences do (watch, react, fail to look away).

PLAYER 1 *(as Door-keeper) [cap in hand]*. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt...

THE MANAGER *[rudely]*. Eh? What is it?

PLAYER 1 *(as Door-keeper) [timidly]*. These people are asking for you, sir.

THE MANAGER *[without looking up from the letter]*. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! *[Turning to the CHARACTERS.]* Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER *[coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed]*. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

THE MANAGER *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[vivaciously]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh, do you hear that? *Alors*.

THE FATHER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To MANAGER.]* unless you would be willing...

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer, voice softening on each clause]*. Oh sir, you know well that life is full of infinite absurdities, which, strangely enough, do not even need to appear plausible, since they are true.

THE MANAGER. What the devil is he talking about?

THE FATHER. I say that reversing the ordinary process may well seem like madness: that is, to create credible situations, so that they appear true. But let me point out that if this be madness, it is the sole *raison d'être* of your profession, gentlemen. *[The ACTORS look hurt and perplexed.]*

THE MANAGER *[getting up and looking at him]*. So our profession seems to you one worthy of madmen then?

THE FATHER. Well, to make seem true that which isn't true... without any need... for a joke as it were... Isn't that your mission, gentlemen: to give life to fantastic characters on the stage?

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the COMPANY]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets to represent instead of men, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards! *[The ACTORS, satisfied, applaud their MANAGER.]*

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly, to living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes: beings less real perhaps, but truer! I agree with you entirely. *[The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.]*

THE MANAGER. But what do you mean? Before, you said...

THE FATHER. No, excuse me, I meant it for you, sir, who were crying out that you had no time to lose with madmen, while no one better than yourself knows that nature uses the instrument of human fantasy to pursue her high creative purpose.

THE MANAGER. Very well, — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere! It is merely to show you that one is born to life in many forms, in many shapes, as tree, or as stone, as water, as butterfly, or as woman. So one may also be born a character in a play.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

THE FATHER *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, chuck it! Get away please! Clear out of here! *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of — not before lunch, anyway. Not on a Tuesday. Not in Lausanne.

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the PROMPTER'S box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards MANAGER, smiling and coquettish]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

THE FATHER. Yes, that is the word! *[To Manager.]* The author who created us alive no longer wished, or was no longer able, to put us into a work of art. That was a real crime, sir. He who is born a character can laugh even at death. The writer dies; the creation does not — and it needs no extraordinary gift to live forever. Who was Sancho Panza? Who was Madame Bovary? They live eternally, because they found a fantasy that could nourish them. We had no such fortune.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

PLAYER 3. Just listen to him. Honestly — just listen.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. They want to live, in us...

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)* *[pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER]*. I've no objection, as far as that one is concerned!

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the MANAGER.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon concert it among ourselves.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to concert? We don't go in for concerts here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[crossing behind the Father, fingers trailing across his shoulder]*. My passion, sir! Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. *[Points to the FATHER and pretends to throw her arms around him, then bursts into a coarse, carrying laugh.]*

THE FATHER *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.]*

*Les chinois sont un peuple malin,
De Shanghai à Pékin,
Ils ont mis des écriteaux partout:
Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.*

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Bravo! Well done! Tip-top!

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the FATHER in consternation.]* Is she mad?

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when God takes this little darling from her mother, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest things — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

THE MOTHER *[to the MANAGER, in anguish]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands, in desperation]*. I beg you, sir, to prevent this man from carrying out his plan which is loathsome to me.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

THE MOTHER *[with a cry]*. No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here — look at her a moment and you will understand — because her drama isn't a drama of the love of two men for whom she could feel nothing except, perhaps, a little gratitude — gratitude not for me but for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother, and her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies, in fact, all in these four children she has had by two men.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? *[To the COMPANY.]* It was his doing. It was he who gave me that other man, who forced me to go away with him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

THE MOTHER *[startled]*. Not true, isn't it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

THE MOTHER. And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son

there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he [*Indicates the FATHER.*] made her do so.

THE MOTHER [*vigorously*]. He forced me to it, and I call God to witness it. [*To the MANAGER.*] Ask him [*Indicates HUSBAND.*] if it isn't true. Let him speak. You [*To DAUGHTER.*] are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. [*Turning on the chair-and-coat, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.*] It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

THE MOTHER. Leave the poor boy alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have answered him that I didn't abandon my house and my son through any fault of mine, nor from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 (*as Leading Man*) [*to the COMPANY*]. What a spectacle. What an absolute treat. I shall write to my agent — if I still have one in this country.

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 (*as Juvenile Lead*). For once, in a way.

THE MANAGER [*beginning to get really interested*]. Let's hear them out. Listen!

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. [*To the MANAGER.*] He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

THE SON [*with disgust*]. Yes, phrases! phrases!

THE FATHER. Phrases! Isn't everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn't understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even in the case of remorse. In fact, especially then.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was a bit of money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — for what I was selling that afternoon... [*Sensation of horror among the ACTORS.*]

THE SON [*to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who lure poor girls of good family into their ateliers, on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*.

THE SON. And he thinks he has bought the right to tyrannize over us all with those hundred francs he was going to pay; but which, fortunately — note this, gentlemen — he had no chance of paying.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! [*Laughs ironically.*]

THE MOTHER [*protesting*]. Shame, my daughter, shame!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, should turn your backs now — I am almost nude in this scene. I do not blush, however. *He* does. [*Indicating FATHER.*]

THE MANAGER. I don't understand this at all.

THE FATHER. Naturally enough. I would ask you, sir, to exercise your authority a little here, and let me speak before you believe all she is trying to blame me with. Let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. But don't you see that the whole trouble lies here. In words, words. Each one of us has within him a whole world of things, his own special world. And how can we ever understand each other, if I give my words the sense I have in me, while you who listen must translate them according to the conception of things you have within yourself? We think we understand. We never really do.

THE MOTHER. But you drove me away.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

THE MOTHER. You know how to talk, and I don't; but, believe me, sir [*To MANAGER.*], after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor insignificant woman...

THE FATHER. But, good Heavens! it was just for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. [*He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide in sign of desperation, seeing how hopeless it is to make himself understood.*] You see she denies it. Her mental deafness, believe me, is total: [*Touches his forehead.*] deaf, deaf, mentally deaf! She has plenty of feeling. Oh yes, a good heart for the children; but the brain — deaf, to the point of desperation —!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? [*At this point the LEADING LADY who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the LEADING MAN flirting with the STEP-DAUGHTER, comes forward and says to the MANAGER.*]

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 3 (*as Juvenile Lead*). This is something quite new.

PLAYER 1 (*as L'Ingénue*). Most interesting. In a kind of educational way. The canton will be thrilled.

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent. In Lausanne. In francs. [*Casts a glance at LEADING MAN.*]

THE MANAGER [*to FATHER*]. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. [*Sits down.*]

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how I was to be kept in countenance, how I was to be kept quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage, to exasperate me beyond measure.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman drifting forlornly about the house like an animal without a master, like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

THE FATHER [*suddenly turning to the MOTHER*]. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*pointing to him ironically*]. As one can see.

THE FATHER [*quickly*]. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's atelier. A very regular customer.

THE FATHER. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man! This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a live man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes, I admit it. It was also a liberation for me. But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir; and I did it more for her sake than mine — I swear it. [*Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.*] Did I ever lose sight of you until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, that had no base motive in it, I watched with the tenderest concern the new family that grew up around her. [*Points to the Step-Daughter.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was a kiddie, so so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and knickers longer than my skirts, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she [*Indicating the Mother.*] went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here [*Indicating the Son.*] was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street and smile at me, wave his hand like this. I looked at him, doubtful, wondering who he might be. I told my mother, who guessed at once. [*The Mother agrees with a nod.*] Then she wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again — looking so ridiculous — with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers, all for me.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

THE SON [*contemptuously*]. Literature! Literature!

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She [*Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.*], as you see, is no longer the flapper with plaits down her back —.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the knickers showing below the skirt!

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. Through her stupidity! [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] It's true she can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write to me that they were in need...

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

THE FATHER. That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

THE MOTHER. After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them, and naturally my interest dwindled. But the drama culminated, unforeseen and violent, on their return — when I was impelled by my miserable flesh that still lives. Ah, what wretchedness is that of the man who is alone and disdains debasing liaisons! Not old enough to do without women, not young enough to seek one without shame. It is worse than misery; it is a horror. Every man knows what unconfessable things pass in the secrecy of his own heart. One gives way to temptation, and rises again with a great eagerness to re-establish one's dignity, as a tombstone on the grave of one's shame. Some folks haven't the courage to say certain things, that's all.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Therefore, you want more courage to say these things. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But it isn't true. He is like all the others — better indeed, because he isn't afraid to reveal with the light of intelligence the red shame of human bestiality which most men close their eyes upon. Woman — look at her case. She turns inviting glances on you. You seize her. No sooner does she feel herself in your grasp than she closes her eyes. It is the sign of her mission, by which she says: "Blind yourself, for I am blind."

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes she can close them no more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only that of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the beast in man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life bestially, throwing aside every chaste aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

THE MANAGER. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve hers in a different way.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor mamma! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my frocks, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's robes.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*treacherously*]. Almost in time!

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No, in time! in time! Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her; and I who cannot look her in the face.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. For the drama lies all in this — in the conscience that I have, that each one of us has. We believe this conscience to be a single thing; but it is many-sided. So we have the illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. We perceive this when, tragically perhaps, in something we do, we are caught up, suspended on a kind of hook. Then we see that all of us was not in that act, and that it would be an atrocious injustice to judge us by that action alone, as if all our existence were summed up in that one deed. Now do you understand the perfidy of this girl? She surprised me in a place where she ought not to have known me — and now seeks to attach to me a reality I could never have supposed I would have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life.

THE SON [*shrugging his shoulders scornfully*]. Leave me alone! I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it, and don't want to have; because you know well enough I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — *you!* I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. I'd like Mr. Manager to witness certain scenes between him and me. He says I have tyrannised. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. But imagine, gentlemen, the position of a son who sees arrive one day at his home a young woman of impudent bearing, asking for his father — with whom, who knows what business she has. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there. He has to watch her treat his father in an equivocal and confidential manner. She asks him for money — in a way that lets one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever bother your head about me?

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the MOTHER to the MANAGER.*] See, she's crying!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*angrily, stamping her foot*]. Like a fool!

THE FATHER [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. He disappears soon, you know. And the baby too. She is the first to vanish from the scene. The drama consists finally in this: when that mother re-enters my house, her family — born outside of it and

superimposed on the original — ends with the death of the little girl, the tragedy of the boy, and the flight of the elder daughter. It cannot go on, because it is foreign to its surroundings. So we three remain — I, the mother, that son — and find ourselves strange to one another. We live in an atmosphere of mortal desolation, which is the revenge, as he [*Indicating the Son.*] scornfully said, of the Demon of Experiment that unfortunately hides in me. When faith is lacking, it becomes impossible to create certain states of happiness.

PART III OF ACT ONE

The Bargain

The shop of Madame Pace is named for the first time. The hundred francs. The pale blue envelope. The Father offers his great speech on the many-sided conscience: we are not one self but many, and to be caught in one moment is to be falsified by it. The Manager, who began this part still believing he was being held hostage by lunatics, begins instead to think there is a play in this — perhaps even one his contract should be wishing for. The bargain begins to be struck.

The Step-Daughter is feverish. The Father is in mid-flight. The Son is cold; he announces, without much ceremony, that he does not come into this drama, and that any attempt to make him come into it will fail. The Father describes how the drama ends — the death of the Child by the fountain, the tragedy of the Boy behind the trees, the flight of the Step-Daughter into the night. He describes it not as memory but as fact, already written, already inside him.

The Manager exits to his office with the Characters to organise the rehearsal. The Players are left on stage in a small chorus of bewilderment — the Door-keeper protesting he only let them in, the Property Man muttering that first the script made no sense and now the audience walks in off the street, the Prompter asking, in shorthand, in shorthand? The curtain falls on a theatre that has not yet decided whether it has been broken into or rescued.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	13 speeches · 230 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	1 speech · 7 words
<i>The Father</i>	12 speeches · 179 words
<i>Player 1</i>	7 speeches · 145 words
<i>Player 3</i>	6 speeches · 97 words
<i>Player 2</i>	3 speeches · 80 words
Total	42 speeches · 738 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Father's long monologues are the philosophical engine of the act. They must be played as urgent, not as essays. A man arguing for his life is not a man lecturing.
- The Son's refusal is itself a performance. He should be aware of how dramatic his refusal is. That awareness is the comedy underneath the metaphysics.
- The Manager's pivot from cynic to interested party is the act's quiet pivot. Play it with both relief and unease.
- The final actor chorus is comic relief after a metaphysical climb. Don't undercut it; let the audience laugh again before the act ends.
- The Step-Daughter's narration of the shop scene must already contain the cold accounting we will hear from Madame Pace in Act Two. She is rehearsing the transaction for herself even as she describes it.
- By the curtain, the work-lights are gone and the rehearsal-room atmosphere is gone. We are inside the family's drama now, even though officially we are still backstage.

THE MANAGER. There is something in what you say. I assure you all this interests me very much. I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this, and not a bad drama either.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[coming forward]*. When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER *[shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the MANAGER]*. You be quiet!

THE MANAGER *[reflecting, heedless of interruption]*. It's new... hem... yes...

THE FATHER. Absolutely new!

THE MANAGER. You've got a nerve though, I must say, to come here and fling it at me like this...

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

THE FATHER. No sir, no. We act that rôle for which we have been cast, that rôle which we are given in life. And in my own case, passion itself, as usually happens, becomes a trifle theatrical when it is exalted.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then why not turn author now? Everybody does it. You don't want any special qualities. Your task is made much easier by the fact that we are all here alive before you...

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

THE MANAGER. By Jove, it tempts me. I'd like to have a go at it. Let's try it out. Come with me to my office. *[Turning to the ACTORS.]* You are at liberty for a bit, but don't step out of the theatre for long. In a quarter of an hour, twenty minutes, all back here again! *[To the FATHER.]* We'll see what can be done. Who knows if we don't get something really extraordinary out of it?

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the ACTORS.]* Be punctual, please! *[MANAGER and the Six CHARACTERS cross the stage and go off. The other ACTORS remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Is he serious? What does he want — improv? Devised work? I did not sign on with Village Players for devised work.

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. This is rank madness. Beautiful rank madness — but madness.

PLAYER 1. Does he expect us to knock up a drama in five minutes? On a Tuesday? With the M2 closing at half-past midnight?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Like the improvisers!

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). If he thinks I'm taking part in a joke like this — without seeing the contract first — he is gravely mistaken.

PLAYER 3 (*as Juvenile Lead*). I'm out of it anyway. I have a thing on Tuesday — a reading at the SSA, or a class, I forget. Either way: booked.

PLAYER 2. I would like to know who they are. I would also like to know who let them in — and through which door, because the side one is supposed to be locked. [*Alludes to CHARACTERS.*]

PLAYER 1. What do you reckon? Madmen, rascals — or, more likely, both.

PLAYER 3 (*as Juvenile Lead*). And he takes them seriously! He has notes. There is — I can see from here — a notebook.

PLAYER 1 (*as L'Ingénue*). Vanity. He thinks he's an author now. By Friday he'll think he is Pirandello.

PLAYER 1 (*as Leading Man*). It's absolutely unheard of. If the stage has come to this — well, I'm going back to television. To Geneva, even, if I must. At least on television the audience cannot walk onto the set.

PLAYER 3. It's rather a joke. It will be a much funnier joke later, I'm sure — over a drink at the bar, once we've all stopped being characters.

PLAYER 1. Well, we'll see what's going to happen next.

PLAYER 2 (*as Property Man*). First the script makes no sense, now the audience walks in off the street. I love this country, but its theatre is — *voilà* — finished.

PLAYER 1 (*as Door-keeper*). I only let them in. Don't blame me. They had the look of money. I thought they were patrons. From Vevey, possibly. They had that — *vous voyez* — that air about them.

PLAYER 3 (*as Prompter*). And I'm to take this down in shorthand, am I? — In shorthand.

Thus talking, the **ACTORS** leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.

✦

— *End of Act I* —

The curtain remains up. The action of the play is suspended for twenty minutes.



ACT THE SECOND

II



PART I OF ACT TWO

Backstage

The act opens with a transformation of the set. The bare chair-circle of Act One is gone; what is revealed is built on two levels. The upper platform is the rehearsal stage — where the family's drama will be staged. The lower floor is everything outside the performance: where the actors watch, where the Six wait between scenes, where the technical apparatus of the house lives. The Step-Daughter erupts from the lower floor onto the upper platform with the wrapped bundle in her arms and the chair-and-coat at her side. She has just lost an argument we did not witness. The Son and Mother emerge after her on the lower floor, circling each other in silence and accusation. The Father follows last.

The rear wall lights up. The Step-Daughter is shown in video, kneeling — addressing the Child as a real four-year-old, telling her about the imaginary garden and the imaginary fountain and the make-believe water. Partway through, on the same screen, she seizes the Boy and finds the revolver in his pocket. Her voice plays from the speakers. Below the screen, her live body stands silent. This is the only projection in the production with audible voice. The bundle and the chair-and-coat remain on the live stage, visible in front of the screen. When the projection ends, they are once again only objects.

Then the apparatus of the theatre reasserts itself — all of it now on the upper platform. The Property Man carries the table up. The Machinist places the pegs. The folding screen is wheeled into position. The white parlour is fitted up on the upper level, built around the family's pain like furniture, because that is what theatres do with grief. The Prompter takes shorthand from his box on the lower floor. The Manager paces between levels as he assigns names to the Characters. The Father falters at the sound of his own name.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	13 speeches · 343 words
<i>The Father</i>	24 speeches · 460 words
<i>The Manager</i>	37 speeches · 762 words
<i>The Son</i>	2 speeches · 131 words
<i>The Mother</i>	1 speech · 33 words
<i>Player 1</i>	6 speeches · 73 words

<i>Player 2</i>	11 speeches · 95 words
<i>Player 3</i>	2 speeches · 8 words
<i>The Manager and The Father</i>	1 speech · 5 words
<i>All Three Players</i>	3 speeches · 39 words
<i>Two Players</i>	1 speech · 5 words
Total	101 speeches · 1,954 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Step-Daughter's projected monologue is the production's most technically delicate moment. Live body silent, recorded voice playing, audience reading both at once. The video and the live performer must look like the same body in two states.
- The Mother's circling of the Son is a silent duel. Stage it physically — proximity, evasion, the refusal to meet the eyes. No words yet.
- The Property Man should bring in the furniture as if for any other rehearsal, not as if for a family's tragedy. The casualness of the work is the cruelty of this part.
- The Father's stumble at his own name is the small moment that signals the rest of the act. Mark it. Do not over-play it.
- The Step-Daughter's live body, while the video plays, should be doing something specific. Watching herself? Looking away? Holding the bundle? Choose, and commit.
- Use the working lights again here for the technical setup. Atmospheric lighting comes back only when Madame Pace is summoned.

The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER comes out of the MANAGER'S office carrying the wrapped bundle and dragging the wooden chair-and-coat behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the chair-and-coat to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

► PROJECTION BEGINS

The only projection in the production with audible dialogue. The rear wall lights up. The Step-Daughter is shown in video, kneeling, addressing the Child as a real four-year-old; partway through, she seizes the Boy by the arm — also live in the video — and finds the revolver. The bundle and the chair-and-coat remain visible on the live stage in front of the screen. Her voice plays from the speakers, not from the live Step-Daughter, who stands silent below.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the Child and takes her face between her hands].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to a question of the Child.]* What is the stage? It's a place, baby, where people play at being serious — and we've got to act a comedy now, dead serious. You're in it too. A garden — a fountain — look — just suppose, kiddie, it's here, right in the middle. It's all pretence, my pet. All make-believe here. Better to imagine it, because if they fix it up for you, it'll only be painted cardboard — for the rockery, the water, the plants. Ah, but I think a baby like this would sooner have a make-believe fountain than a real one. What a joke it'll be for the others! But for you, alas, not such a joke. You who are real, baby dear, and really play by a real fountain, big and green and beautiful, with bamboos around and a whole lot of little ducks swimming. — *[In the video, the Step-Daughter seizes the Boy by the arm.]* What have you got there? *[In the video, she catches the glint of a revolver in his pocket.]* Ah! Where did you get this? Idiot! If I'd been in your place, instead of killing myself I'd have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

■ PROJECTION ENDS

The screen cuts to black. The Step-Daughter is once again live below it, alone with the bundle and the chair. The voice has stopped. The Boy and Child are objects on the stage again.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

THE MANAGER *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The FATHER, MANAGER and STEP-DAUGHTER go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, THE SON followed by THE MOTHER, comes out.]*

THE SON *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine, fine! And to think I can't even get away! *[The MOTHER attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the bundle into her lap and draws the chair-and-coat close beside her. She casts a glance again at the SON, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

THE MOTHER. And isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the SON's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God! Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to support all this torment? Must you make others see it too?

THE SON *[half to himself, meaning the Mother to hear].* And they want to put it on the stage! If there was at least a reason for it! He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us in every circumstance of life couldn't find his own explanation of it! *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live and are man and wife for themselves, quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

The MOTHER hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the ACTORS and STAGE MANAGER return, followed by the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER. At the same moment, THE MANAGER comes out of his office, accompanied by the FATHER and the STEP-DAUGHTER.

THE MANAGER. Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Heh! you there, machinist!

PLAYER 1 *(as Machinist).* Yes sir?

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

The MACHINIST runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while THE MANAGER talks with the STAGE MANAGER, the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER on matters of detail.

THE MANAGER *[to PROPERTY MAN].* Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* There's the green one.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* There isn't one like that.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [to MANAGER].* There's that little gilt one.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

THE FATHER. A mirror.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

PLAYER 2 (*as Property Man*). That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

THE MANAGER [*to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, several, several!

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

PLAYER 2 (*as Property Man*). All right!

The PROPERTY MAN hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the MANAGER talks to the PROMPTER and then with the CHARACTERS and the ACTORS.

THE MANAGER [*to PROMPTER*]. Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. [*Hands him some sheets of paper.*] And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

PLAYER 3 (*as Prompter*). Take it down in shorthand?

THE MANAGER [*pleasantly surprised*]. Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

PLAYER 3 (*as Prompter*). Yes, a little.

THE MANAGER. Good! [*Turning to a STAGE HAND.*] Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. [*The STAGE HAND goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the PROMPTER.*]

THE MANAGER [*to PROMPTER*]. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. [*Then addressing the ACTORS.*] Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here [*Pointing to the left.*] and listen attentively.

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). But, excuse me, we...

THE MANAGER [*guessing her thought*]. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

PLAYER 1 (*as Leading Man*). What have we to do then — sit and applaud? I can do that. I've been doing that all season — at every other company's premiere in the canton, in fact.

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

THE FATHER [*as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage*]. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. [*Points to the ACTORS.*]

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" [*Pointing towards PROMPTER'S box.*] — when there is a "book"!

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

THE FATHER. As we are...

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

PLAYER 1 (*as Leading Man*). What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! [*The ACTORS laugh.*] There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. [*To the SECOND LADY LEAD.*] You play the Mother. [*To the FATHER.*] We must find her a name.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... [*Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the SECOND LADY LEAD.*] I see this woman here [*Means the MOTHER.*] as Amalia. But do as you like. [*Gets more and more confused.*] I don't know what to say to you. Already I begin to hear my own words ring false — as if they had a different sound...

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: [*To JUVENILE LEAD.*] You are the Son. [*To the LEADING LADY.*] You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*excitedly*]. What? what? I, that woman there? [*Bursts out laughing.*]

THE MANAGER [*angry*]. What is there to laugh at?

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*) [*indignant*]. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go. And I take half this audience with me. They come for me. Most of them are friends of mine.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

THE MANAGER [*to STEP-DAUGHTER*]. You should feel honored to be played by...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul, be hanged! Do you suppose the spirit of the piece is in you? Nothing of the kind!

THE FATHER. What, haven't we our own temperaments, our own souls?

THE MANAGER. Not at all. Your soul or whatever you like to call it takes shape here. The actors give body and form to it, voice and gesture. And my actors have given voice to material far more lofty than this little drama of yours — which may or may not hold up on the stage. But if it does, the merit of it, believe me, will be due to my actors.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

THE MANAGER *[cutting him short and out of patience]*. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up...

THE FATHER. Maybe. But the voice, the gestures...

THE MANAGER. Now, look here! On the stage, you as yourself, cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[on his dignity]*. By me, if you've no objection!

THE FATHER *[with a small bow toward Player 1]*. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Oh — chuck it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

THE FATHER. The performance he will give, even doing his best with make-up to look like me...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. It will certainly be a bit difficult! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Exactly! It will be difficult to act me as I really am. The effect will be more — apart from the make-up — how he supposes I am, how he senses me — if he senses me at all — and not how I, inside myself, feel myself to be. So it seems to me that anyone whose job it becomes to criticise us should take this into account...

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the ACTORS and CHARACTERS.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Is it all right as it is now?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the FATHER.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

THE FATHER. Yes.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The STAGE HANDS obey the order. To PROPERTY MAN.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates FATHER.]*

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The LEADING LADY comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* You just watch —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[adding at once].* How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [offended].* I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

THE MANAGER *[with his hands to his head].* Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done?

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! *[Turning to the ACTRESSES.]* If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[half surprised, half laughing, in chorus].*

What? Why? Our hats? What does he say?

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

ALL THREE PLAYERS.

Oh, what d'you think of that? Only the mantle? He must be mad.

TWO PLAYERS.

But why? Mantles as well?

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[taking off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and going to hang them on the racks].*

After all, why not? There you are! This is really funny. We've got to put them on show.

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? *[Inviting the ACTORS to look towards the exit at back of stage.]* Look! Look!

PART II OF ACT TWO

The Apparition

The Father asks the actresses if they would mind hanging their hats and mantles on the pegs at the back of the upper platform. They climb up to do so, half-amused, not knowing why. The Father asks them to look toward the door upstage. The door opens. Madame Pace appears on the upper level — though she was not in the original six, and no one called her, and no one walks through a stage door on cue. The Step-Daughter, on the platform with her, recognises her at once.

This is the production's strangest scene, and the most architecturally bold. A Character not in the original cast list is summoned onto the upper level by the very arrangement of the stage — by the hats on the pegs, by the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), by the folding screen. Player 3 enters her costume the way an apparition enters a body. She is fat, bleach-blonde, rouged — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in Lausanne long enough to half-forget her first language and never quite learn her second. She speaks half in Italian and half in French, and the actors laugh at the dialect before they understand what it is saying. What it is saying is a procurement transaction. She is a bookkeeper of the trade — the silk the Mother has ruined, the column that must balance, the cash in the blue envelope, the chicken not slaughtered where the hen can see. The Step-Daughter begins to play the scene of the atelier with her, drawn back into a room she has been in before.

Then the Mother sees her, from the lower floor. The Mother, who has barely spoken in this play, looks up at the upper platform and erupts: *You old devil! You murderess!* Her voice crosses from below to above. The temperature in the room collapses in seconds. The scene of the shop cannot be played in the presence of its witness. The play breaks its own scene, and the actors, watching from the wings, do not understand what they are watching.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	20 speeches · 379 words
<i>The Father</i>	12 speeches · 355 words
<i>The Manager</i>	15 speeches · 350 words
<i>Player 1</i>	5 speeches · 46 words
<i>Player 3</i>	7 speeches · 238 words

Player 2

2 speeches · 19 words

The Mother

3 speeches · 20 words

Total

64 speeches · 1,407 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- Madame Pace's entrance must feel inexplicable to the audience. The folding screen, the hats, the shop window — let the audience read them as set-dressing, not as summoning.
- Player 3's transformation is the production's most demanding moment. The wig, the heels, the powder — every visual element must commit. The dialect must be performed with no protective irony.
- The Step-Daughter does not flirt with Madame Pace; she is being handled by her. Play the proximity as a woman who has been in this room before and knows the price of every silk. The audience may laugh at the dialect at first — that laughter must curdle inside Madame's "Not so old, *cara*" aria.
- The pale blue envelope and the hundred francs are the props that make the scene material. Treat them with weight. They are not symbols; they are evidence.
- The Mother's eruption is triggered on a specific line — Madame Pace's *Not so old, cara. He clean. He polite. He pay cash... He bury it deep.* That is the beat that breaks her silence; mark it in the score. She has been silent for an entire act and a half. She finds her voice in one breath, and the room changes with her.
- The Mother's silence before and after that eruption is the architecture of the scene. The actor must commit to the silence as much as to the cry.

*The door at the back of stage opens and **MADAME PACE** enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair. She is rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The **STEP-DAUGHTER** runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [turning towards her]. There she is! There she is!

THE FATHER [radiant]. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

THE MANAGER *[conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]*. What sort of a trick is this?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[almost at the same time]*. What's going to happen next?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Where does *she* come from? Not from the SSA list, I can tell you that.

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue)*. They've been holding her in reserve, I suppose. Saving her for the big effect.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. A vulgar trick. And not even a good one.

THE FATHER *[dominating the protests]*. Excuse me, all of you! Why are you so anxious to destroy, in the name of a vulgar, commonplace sense of truth, this reality which comes to birth, attracted and formed by the magic of the stage itself — which has indeed more right to live here than you, since it is much truer than you, if you don't mind my saying so? Which is the actress among you who is to play Madame Pace? Well, here is Madame Pace herself. You'll allow, I fancy, that the actress who acts her will be less true than this woman, who is herself in person.

*But the scene between the **STEP-DAUGHTER** and **MADAME PACE** has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of **THE FATHER**. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by **THE FATHER**, turn round and see **MADAME PACE**, who has placed one hand under the **STEP-DAUGHTER'S** chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.*

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. What does she say?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. One can't hear a word. I would have preferred surtitles.

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Louder! Louder please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[leaving **MADAME PACE**, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors]*. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. *[Indicates **FATHER**.]* But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

*The **STEP-DAUGHTER** coquettishly and with a touch of malice makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.*

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[sotto voce, mysteriously]*. There's someone who will hear us if she *[Indicating MADAME PACE.]* speaks out loud.

THE MANAGER *[in consternation]*. What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. *[Moves away.]*

THE MANAGER *[stopping him]*. No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting him]*. No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

THE MANAGER *[shouting]*. But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... *[Indicates MADAME PACE.]* Do you understand?...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that mamma's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)* *[coming forward with an air of great importance]*. Sì sì, signor — I no wanta be hard. I no wanta take advantage. But la signora she ruin the silk again, è la terza volta this month. *La seta non si paga con le lacrime*. Somebody must pay. The mamma she pay with the hands — or è la piccola who pay. Either way, the book she balance.

Note. MADAME PACE is supposed to talk in a jargon half Italian, half French — the speech of a Ticinese woman who has lived in Lausanne too long and not long enough.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed]*. What? What? She talks like that? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing again.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing]*. Yes yes, that's the way she talks, half French, half Italian! Most comical it is!

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)*. Itta seem not verra polite gentlemen laugha atta me — when I trya speak proper for the *clientela*. My customers — they no laugh. They come back.

THE MANAGER. *Diamine!* Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect will be certain. Exactly what was needed to put a little comic relief into the crudity of the situation. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her

inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old signore, eh, Madame?

PLAYER 3 (as Madame Pace). Not so old, *cara*. Not so old. He clean. He polite. He pay cash, every time — *la busta azzurra* on the little table, you no even gotta look at his face. And eef you no lika him? Eh — *niente scandalo*. Nobody talk. He bury it deep, like everything else in this town.

THE MOTHER [jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her]. You old devil! You murderess!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [running over to calm her MOTHER]. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

THE FATHER [going to her also at the same time]. Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

THE MOTHER. Well then, take that woman away out of my sight!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [to MANAGER]. It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER [to MANAGER]. They can't be here together. And for this reason, you see: that woman there was not with us when we came... If they are on together, the whole thing is given away inevitably, as you see.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... [Turning to the MOTHER and leading her to her chair.] Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Meanwhile, the STEP-DAUGHTER, coming forward again, turns to MADAME PACE.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

PLAYER 3 (as Madame Pace) [offended]. Eh no, *grazie*. The mamma present — *è impossibile*. I have my method, signor. The mamma stay outside, or the transaction it no close. *Anche le galline*. Even the chickens — you no slaughter them where the hen can see.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old signore* who wants to talk so nicely to me. [Addressing the COMPANY imperiously.] We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! [To MADAME PACE.] You can go!

PLAYER 3 (as Madame Pace). Sì sì, *certo*. I go. I go. Ma *cara* — you remember. Without me, *niente*. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty. *È a me che devi tutto*. La Pace. Don't you forget the name. [Exits furious.]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [to the FATHER]. Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good morning, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the FATHER, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

The FATHER does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The ACTORS watch intently.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the PROMPTER in his box].* Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

THE FATHER *[coming forward and speaking in a different tone].* Good afternoon, Miss!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust].* Good afternoon!

THE FATHER *[looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure].* Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[modestly].* No sir.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust].* No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

The MOTHER, who watches the progress of the scene with THE SON beside her, the bundle held tight in her arms and the chair-and-coat pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.

THE MOTHER. Oh, my God, my God!

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry].* Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue) [interrupting].* I say... those are our hats you know.

THE MANAGER *[furious].* Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Begin again, please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[continuing].* No thank you, sir.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[all keyed up]*. No, it's not that — I couldn't wear it because I am... as you see... you might have noticed... *[Showing her black dress.]*

THE FATHER. ... in mourning! Of course: I beg your pardon: I'm frightfully sorry...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea]*. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[interrupting and turning to the PROMPTER]*. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the FATHER only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the ACTORS.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! *[To the ACTORS.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

PART III OF ACT TWO

The Substitution

The Father and the Step-Daughter play out the first beats of the shop scene themselves, on the upper platform. The lines they say are the lines they actually said, some years ago, in a back room of a real dressmaker's atelier in Lausanne. The Manager listens from below. The actors watch from below. The Mother trembles on the lower floor. Then the Manager hands the scene to his Leading Lady and Leading Man — they climb up to the platform, taking the place of the Characters, and try the same lines. The Step-Daughter, also up there, laughs at them.

The Players push through it: the hat-offer, the refusal, the mourning reveal, the *I'm frightfully sorry*. They do not break on a laugh. They break on a correction. The Step-Daughter, almost to herself: *He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.* The Father, quietly: *Yes. He said "Oh."* The Leading Lady will not be corrected this precisely by the originals of her part, and she walks. The Leading Man walks after her. The Mother, from the lower floor, breaks in: *It's taking place now. It happens all the time.* She cries out as she did in life, from below up into the rehearsal stage. The Machinist, by accident, drops the curtain on what was supposed to be only a rehearsal effect.

This is the act's first real climax. Pirandello forces the audience to watch the same scene twice and feel both versions as inadequate — the live one too raw, the rehearsed one too polished. The audience leaves the act unsettled and a little ashamed of having been entertained.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>Player 2</i>	12 speeches · 149 words
<i>Player 1</i>	12 speeches · 223 words
<i>The Manager</i>	40 speeches · 714 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	23 speeches · 573 words
<i>The Father</i>	12 speeches · 168 words
<i>The Mother</i>	4 speeches · 107 words
Total	103 speeches · 1,934 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- Two performances of the same shop scene, back to back, must feel like two genres. The Characters' version is shame in real time; the Actors' version is rehearsal-room polish — competent, well-paced, well-meaning, and exactly wrong. The Leading Lady's voice catches where she has been taught it should catch. That is the cruelty.
- The Step-Daughter's laughter at the Leading Lady must not be mocking. It must be heartbroken. She is watching her worst hour be made decorative.
- The Leading Lady and Leading Man — Players 2 and 1 — must not be in on the joke. They believe they are doing fine work. They walk out not from humiliation but from professional offence: *I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath*. The audience should be embarrassed for them and for itself.
- The Mother's *It's taking place now* is the moral centre of the play. Surround it with silence. Let the actors freeze around her. Then the curtain falls before they can recover.
- The accidental curtain-drop must look genuinely accidental. The Machinist (Player 1) should look surprised. The audience should be unsure for a half-second whether the play is over.
- The act ends not on a line but on the collapse of the curtain. Calibrate the descent — neither slow nor fast, but inevitable.

PLAYER 2 (as Leading Lady). Of course! It's easy enough! [To LEADING MAN.] Shall you and I try it now?

PLAYER 1 (as Leading Man). Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [Exit to make his entrance.]

THE MANAGER [to LEADING LADY]. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2 (as Leading Lady). One minute. I want to put my hat on again. [Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 (as Leading Lady). But I'll be, and much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER [to STEP-DAUGHTER]. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. [Clapping his hands.] Come on! come on! Entrance, please! [The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first

words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the **STEP-DAUGHTER** and the **FATHER**, not being able to recognize themselves in the **LEADING LADY** and the **LEADING MAN**, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating LEADING LADY.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of, shall we say, equivocal character — and we all know what we mean — then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.]* Well?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good, but not quite so heavily. Like this. *[Acts himself.]* "This isn't the first time that you have come here"... *[To LEADING LADY.]* And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. No, sir.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING MAN]*. Go on!

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The LEADING MAN says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the STEP-DAUGHTER, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Oh come now, don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here, and Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. No, no — I couldn't wear it.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[smiling, well-meaning]*. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the PROMPTER]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [breaking character, to MANAGER]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[almost cheerful]*. We will not.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [indignant]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of by better.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Neither am I. I am through. With this play, this company, this — actually, no, only this scene.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners; that's what it is! You go too far.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

THE FATHER. Just so: actors! Both of them act our parts exceedingly well. But, believe me, it produces quite a different effect on us. They want to be us, but they aren't, all the same.

THE MANAGER. What is it, then?

THE FATHER. Something that is... that is theirs — and no longer ours...

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! [*Turning to the ACTORS.*] We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! [*Turning to FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.*] Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you [*Addressing the FATHER.*] come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*interrupting*]. What?

THE MANAGER. Why she is in mourning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little frock off."

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. What do you want to do then?

THE MANAGER. You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir! What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir, no. He has to say to me, as he did say: *Well, let's take this little frock off.*

THE MANAGER [*running his hands through his hair*]. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*crying out excitedly*]. The truth! The truth!

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

THE MANAGER. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I won't stay here. I will not! I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand! He wants his complicated "cerebral drama" — his remorse, his torments, all performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part!*

THE MANAGER *[annoyed, shaking his shoulders]*. Ah! Just your part! But, if you will pardon me, there are other parts than yours — his *[Indicating the Father.]* and hers *[Indicating the Mother.]*. On the stage you can't have a character becoming too prominent and overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them all into a neat little framework, and then act what isactable. I am aware that everyone has his own interior life he wants to put forward. But the difficulty lies in this: to set out just so much as is necessary for the stage, taking the other characters into consideration, and at the same time hint at the unrevealed interior life of each. From your point of view, it would be a fine idea if each character could tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. *[softening, sitting on the edge of the table]* You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours, this exaggerated disgust, may make a bad impression.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bowing her head, impressed]*. It's true. But remember those others mean him for me all the same.

THE MANAGER *[not understanding]*. What? The others? What do you mean?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act all his "noble remorsees," all his "moral torments," if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? *[She is moved.] [The MOTHER at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[as soon as the MOTHER becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely]*. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

THE MOTHER *[changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]*. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

THE MOTHER. I can't bear it. I can't.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

THE MOTHER. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any

more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment! She *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and hold me eternally in the stocks for that one fleeting and shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up! And you sir, cannot either fairly spare me it.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]*

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.,]* with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them].* No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

THE MANAGER *[walking backwards towards footlights].* Fine! fine! Damned good! And then, of course — curtain!

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly].* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

THE MANAGER *[convinced and pleased].* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

At the reiterated cry of THE MANAGER, THE MACHINIST lets the curtain down, leaving THE MANAGER and THE FATHER in front of it before the footlights.

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the FATHER, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

✧

— *End of Act II* —



ACT THE THIRD

III



PART I OF ACT THREE

The Argument over Reality

The curtain rises on an otherwise empty stage with a single short fountain basin in the middle. The two-level set of Act Two is gone — struck during the interval. There is no garden, no backdrop, no trees, no painted cardboard. Only the basin: stone or concrete, with walls high enough that nobody can see inside it. The chair-and-coat — the Boy — has been moved to the edge of the stage. The bundle is in the Step-Daughter's arms.

The Manager is plotting how to stage a tragedy on an empty stage with one prop. The Step-Daughter complains that this stripped set cannot hold the whole drama, because the Son spends most of the action shut in his room; how can an empty stage contain a man who refuses to come into it? The Father, suddenly philosophical, objects to the word *illusion*. He says the Characters have no other reality outside this one — that the Manager's reality, by contrast, may seem an illusion to him tomorrow. *Can you tell me who you are?*

This is the play's most philosophical stretch. The Father becomes, almost openly, the dramatist that Pirandello cannot help being. The Manager refuses the bait but is visibly unsettled. The Step-Daughter is impatient with the metaphysics — she wants the drama played, not theorised. Yet the Father's argument holds, because of how directly it is aimed: at the Manager, at the actors, at us. The audience is being asked, without warning, whether it exists in the same way the Characters do.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	22 speeches · 250 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	6 speeches · 145 words
<i>The Mother</i>	2 speeches · 28 words
<i>Player 1</i>	2 speeches · 19 words
<i>Player 2</i>	2 speeches · 34 words
<i>The Father</i>	16 speeches · 579 words
Total	50 speeches · 1,055 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The stripped stage of Act Three is the most demanding visual decision. Resist the urge to dress it up. One fountain basin, four live Characters, the chair-and-coat at the side, an empty floor. Light does the rest.
- The Father's *Can you tell me who you are?* must be aimed not at the Manager but at the audience. The actor should let the question land in the house, not on the stage.
- The Manager's discomfort during the philosophical stretch is the audience's discomfort. He is the audience proxy. Play him as a man who would like to leave but cannot.
- The Step-Daughter's impatience keeps the philosophy from becoming a lecture. Use her interruptions.
- The bundle remains in her arms throughout this part. The chair remains at the edge. The Boy and Child are present as objects through every philosophical sentence; the philosophy is happening over their silent bodies.
- The Manager's misnumbering of his own act (*Ah yes: the second act!*) is a quiet joke. Let it land lightly. The audience will catch it.

When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **MOTHER** is sitting on the right, the wrapped bundle in her lap and the chair-and-coat leaned against her knee. The **SON** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **FATHER** and the **STEP-DAUGHTER** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **ACTORS**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **MANAGER** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.

THE MANAGER *[shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]*. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house *[Indicates FATHER.]* in spite of him... *[Indicates the SON.]*

THE MANAGER *[out of patience]*. Leave it to me, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

THE MOTHER *[from her corner, shaking her head]*. For all the good that's come of it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her quickly]*. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

THE MANAGER *[impatiently]*. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

THE MOTHER *[supplicatingly]*. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting indignantly and continuing for the MOTHER]*... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. *[To MANAGER.]* Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

THE MANAGER. Why not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he *[Indicates the SON again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. They used to once. Before health and safety. Before the canton had opinions on flying scenery.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. It makes the illusion easier.

THE FATHER *[irritated]*. The illusion! For Heaven's sake, don't say illusion. Please don't use that word, which is particularly painful for us.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

THE FATHER. It's painful, cruel, really cruel; and you should understand that.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. With our acting.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

THE FATHER. I understand; but you, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me! You see... here for you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so... a kind of game...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [interrupting indignantly].* A game! For heaven's sake — we are not children. We are serious actors. With training — some of us from the Conservatoire. With agents. With opinions on Stanislavski.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five CHARACTERS.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

THE MANAGER *[astonished, looking at his ACTORS, who are also amazed].* And what does that mean?

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile].* As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the MANAGER and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks him in the eyes.]* Can you tell me who you are?

THE MANAGER *[perplexed, half smiling].* What? Who am I? I am myself.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true, because you and I...

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh: because we are all making believe here. *[To MANAGER.]* And so you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the LEADING MAN.]*, who is naturally himself, to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see here. You see I've caught you in a trap! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE MANAGER *[annoyed].* But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

THE FATHER. No, no! That wasn't my meaning! In fact, I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the LEADING LADY as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors, and to ask you seriously once again: who are you?

THE MANAGER *[astonished and irritated, turning to his ACTORS].* If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

THE FATHER *[with dignity, but not offended].* A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features; which is why he is always "somebody." But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be "nobody."

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

THE FATHER. But only to know if you, as you really are now, see yourself as you once were — with all the illusions that were yours then, with all the things both inside and outside of you as they seemed to you, as they were for you. Well, sir, if you think of all those illusions that mean nothing to you now, of all those things which don't even seem to you to exist any more, while once they were for you — don't you feel that the very

earth under your feet is sinking, when you reflect that this you of today is fated to seem a mere illusion to you tomorrow?

THE MANAGER *[without having understood much, but astonished by the specious argument]*. Well, well! And where does all this take us anyway?

THE FATHER. Oh, nowhere! It's only to show you that if we *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* have no other reality beyond the illusion, you too mustn't count too much on your reality as you feel it today — since, like yesterday's, it may turn out to be an illusion to you tomorrow.

THE MANAGER *[determining to make fun of him]*. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

THE FATHER *[with the greatest seriousness]*. But of course; without doubt!

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

THE FATHER *[with a cry]*. No, sir, not ours! Look here! That is the very difference! Our reality doesn't change: it can't change! It can't be other than what it is, because it is already fixed forever. It's terrible. Ours is an immutable reality — which should make you shudder when you approach us, if you are really conscious that your reality is a mere transitory and fleeting illusion, taking this form today and that tomorrow, according to your will. Illusions of reality, represented in this fatuous comedy of life that never ends, nor can ever end.

PART II OF ACT THREE

The Refusal

The Manager tries to combine the garden scene and the indoor scene into one staged action — though there is no garden and no indoor scene, only the fountain basin and the empty stage. The Boy — the chair-and-coat — is to be moved behind the fountain, where it will be partly hidden by the basin. The Child — the bundle — is to be brought down to the basin by the Step-Daughter. The Son is to enter from somewhere off and approach the fountain in time to see the drowning.

The Son refuses. He will not act this. He has never agreed to act it. He cannot leave, but he can refuse to participate, and he intends to. The Step-Daughter laughs at his refusal — he cannot leave, she tells him, because he is *indissolubly bound to the chain*. The Son delivers his speech on the mirror that throws his own likeness back at him as a horrible grimace. He is, in his own family, an image he cannot live with. The Father tries to force him to play the scene. The Mother begs. The Son does not move.

This is the Son's hour. He refuses the play and yet remains in it — the perfect Pirandellian condition. He is the one who has been right all along, and being right does not save him from anything.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Manager</i>	15 speeches · 578 words
<i>The Father</i>	14 speeches · 594 words
<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	8 speeches · 445 words
<i>The Son</i>	7 speeches · 69 words
Total	44 speeches · 1,686 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Son must be physically isolated. Other actors around him; him alone in his frame. Stage him to be unmoveable, not still.
- The Step-Daughter taunts him because she knows he cannot leave. The taunt is therefore loving, not cruel. Find that note.

- The Mother trembles because she knows it too. Her trembling is involuntary, not performed.
- The mirror speech is the Son's only real cry. He must arrive at it. Do not let him perform it from the first beat — he must be surprised, mid-speech, by what he is saying.
- The chair-and-coat is moved behind the fountain basin during this part. Stage the move with weight. The audience should notice a chair being placed behind a basin in an empty stage.
- The Manager is exhausted in this part. Play him as a director who has lost control of his rehearsal and has not yet admitted it.
- No laughter in the room. The comedy has burned off completely. What remains is grief that has not yet found a body.

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... [*Stops and looks him over from head to foot.*] Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. [*Turning to the Actors.*] And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

THE FATHER. I don't know to what author you may be alluding, but believe me, I feel what I think; and I seem to be philosophising only for those who do not think what they feel, because they blind themselves with their own sentiment. I know that for many, this self-blinding seems much more "human"; but the contrary is true. For man never reasons so much, and becomes so introspective, as when he suffers — since he is anxious to get at the cause of his sufferings, to learn who has produced them, and whether it is just that he should have to bear them. The animals suffer without reasoning. But take a man who suffers and begins to reason about it — oh no, it can't be allowed. Let him suffer like an animal, and then — ah yes, he is "human"!

THE MANAGER. Look here! Look here! You're off again, philosophizing worse than ever.

THE FATHER. Because I suffer, sir! I'm not philosophizing; I'm crying aloud the reason of my sufferings.

THE MANAGER [*slaps the table*]. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who gets right out of his part and perorates and speechifies as you do. Have you ever heard of a case? I haven't.

THE FATHER. You have never met such a case, sir, because authors, as a rule, hide the labour of their creations. When the characters are really alive before their author, the latter does nothing but follow them in their actions, their words, the situations they suggest to him; he has to will them the way they will themselves — for there's trouble if he doesn't. When a character is born, he acquires at once such an independence, even of his own author, that everyone can imagine him in many other situations the author never dreamed of placing him in.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? Imagine such a misfortune for characters as I have described to you: to be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him; and then answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they did, and are doing now, after trying everything in their power to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn, I, she *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* and she. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's true. I too have sought to tempt him, many, many times — when he was sitting at his writing table, feeling a bit melancholy at the twilight hour. He would sit in his armchair too lazy to switch on the light, and all the shadows that crept into his room were full of our presence, coming to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Oh, if you would only go away, go away and leave us alone — mother here with that son of hers, I with that Child, that Boy there always alone, and then I with him *[Hinting at the Father.]* — and then I alone, alone, in those shadows. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize herself in the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! Oh, what scenes we proposed to him — and I tempted him more than any of the others!

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? *[Goes close to the MANAGER to tell him, as if in confidence.]* In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

THE SON. Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that!

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

THE SON. No, nothing!

THE MANAGER. You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

THE FATHER. I? When? Where?

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

THE FATHER. Well, if you want to take away from me the possibility of representing the torment of my spirit, which never gives me peace, you will be suppressing me — that's all. Every true man, sir, who is a little above the level of the beasts and plants, does not live for the sake of living, without knowing how to live; but lives so as to give a meaning and a value of his own to life. For me, this is everything. I cannot give it up just to represent a mere fact, as she [*Indicating the Step-Daughter.*] wants. It's all very well for her — but I'm not going to do it. It destroys my *raison d'être*.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits! But for Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. [*Indicating FATHER.*] You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir, wastes him away!

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep with her — I, do you understand? — with my vile contaminated body next to hers, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. [*Calls a Stage Hand.*] A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. [*To Step-Daughter.*] This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. [*To the Boy.*] Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to

say. *[Picks up the chair-and-coat and places it behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the SON.]* You must send him away first.

THE SON *[jumping up]*. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The MOTHER gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

THE SON *[to MANAGER who stops him]*. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly, with irony]*. Don't bother to stop him: he won't go away.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

THE SON *[suddenly resolute and with dignity]*. I will act nothing at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the MANAGER.]* Let me go!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager]*. Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, supporting that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose only son he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see, she was getting up to keep him back. You can imagine how little she wants to show your actors what she really feels — but so eager is she to get near him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

THE SON *[suddenly]*. No! no! If I can't go away, then I'll stop here; but I repeat: I act nothing!

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER excitedly]*. You can force him, sir.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

PART III OF ACT THREE

The Fountain

The Step-Daughter takes the bundle to the fountain. She bends over the basin and lowers the bundle into it — but the basin's walls are high enough that nobody, neither the audience nor the live actors, can see inside it. The drowning happens in plain sight, in an unseeable space. The Son finally tells what he saw on that afternoon: he ran across the garden, he jumped to drag the Child out of the water, and he was frozen by the sight of the Boy standing stock still by the side of the fountain, his eyes mad, watching his little drowned sister.

The rear wall lights up for the first and only time in the production. For roughly ten seconds, a single held shot: the Boy by the fountain, motionless, watching. No camera movement. No sound. Then darkness. From the darkness, the gunshot — from behind the basin, where the chair-and-coat has been placed. The Mother cries out. The actors lift what they think is the Boy's body, which is the chair-and-coat now being treated as a body. Some say he is dead. Others say it is only pretence. The Father, with a terrible cry: *Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!* The Manager has had enough: *Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all! I've lost a whole day over these people. A whole day.* Curtain.

The climax is delivered as memory, not as scene. The drowning is hidden by the basin itself — its walls do the work the Step-Daughter's body used to do. The gunshot comes from behind the same basin, where the chair-and-coat has been placed. The Boy is shown — briefly, motionless, on the rear wall — only as the act of watching, not as the act of dying. This is Pirandello's strictest cruelty: the most terrible thing in the play is the thing the audience does not actually see happen.

WHO SPEAKS, AND HOW MUCH

<i>The Step-Daughter</i>	1 speech · 15 words
<i>The Manager</i>	15 speeches · 142 words
<i>The Son</i>	17 speeches · 274 words
<i>The Mother</i>	6 speeches · 84 words
<i>Player 3</i>	1 speech · 7 words
<i>The Father</i>	6 speeches · 67 words
<i>Two Players</i>	1 speech · 3 words

Total48 speeches · 601 words

FOR THE REHEARSAL ROOM

- The Step-Daughter at the fountain is the play's last live image of love. She is holding a bundle and bending over a basin whose interior nobody can see. Stage the action with the tenderness of the Act Two opening — and trust the basin to do the hiding for you.
- The Son's narration must be the slowest passage in the third act. He is the man who could not move; let his words refuse to move too.
- The ten-second projection must feel unhurried. Hold it. The audience should have time to register what they are seeing — and that this is the only time they are seeing it.
- The gunshot must be a single, sharp report. Choose between startling the audience and not blowing out the speakers.
- The actors lifting the chair-and-coat must treat it as a body. Heavy. Carried with care. The audience reads what the actors give them.
- *Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!* must not be played as resolution. Play it as a contradiction the play cannot solve. The line is a wound, not an answer.
- The Manager's last line is not a punchline. He is tired and contemptuous and right and wrong. Play him as the man who has lost a day. Then the curtain comes down on his exhaustion, not on the family's tragedy.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... *[Lifts the wrapped bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.]*

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

The SECOND LADY LEAD and the JUVENILE LEAD at this point separate themselves from the group of ACTORS. One watches the MOTHER attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the SON whom he will have to act.

THE SON *[to MANAGER]*. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]* Ask her how it was!

THE MOTHER. Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

THE SON. Into my room, do you understand? Nothing to do with the garden.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

THE SON *[observing the JUVENILE LEAD studying him]*. What do you want?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Nothing! I was just looking at you.

THE SON *[turning towards the SECOND LADY LEAD]*. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

THE SON. Yes, but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror which not only freezes us with the image of ourselves, but throws our likeness back at us with a horrible grimace?

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

THE MANAGER *[to SECOND LADY LEAD and JUVENILE LEAD]*. He's right! Move away from them!

THE SON. Do as you like. I'm out of this!

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! *[To MOTHER.]* You were saying you had entered...

THE MOTHER. Yes, into his room, because I couldn't stand it any longer. I went to empty my heart to him of all the anguish that tortures me... But as soon as he saw me come in...

THE SON. Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

THE MOTHER. It's true, true. That's how it was.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

THE MOTHER. I'm ready... when you are ready. If you could only find a chance for me to tell him what I feel here in my heart.

THE FATHER *[going to SON in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

THE SON *[quite determined]*. I do nothing!

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

THE SON *[taking hold of the FATHER]*. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

The MOTHER, frightened, tries to separate them.

THE MOTHER *[pleading]*. Please! please!

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the SON]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

THE SON *[almost crying from rage]*. What does it mean, this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency, that you insist on showing everyone our shame? I won't do it! I won't! And I stand for the will of our author in this. He didn't want to put us on the stage, after all!

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

THE SON *[indicating FATHER]*. He did! I didn't!

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

THE SON. It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

THE SON. Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

THE SON. Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve]*. Well, well... walking in the garden...

THE SON *[exasperated]*. Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! *[The MOTHER trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain.]*

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the SON with increasing apprehension]*. The baby?

THE SON. There in the fountain...

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the MOTHER]*. She was following him at the moment...

THE MANAGER *[to the SON anxiously]*. And then you...

► PROJECTION BEGINS

The rear wall ignites for the first and only time. For roughly ten seconds, a single held shot: THE BOY by the fountain, motionless, watching his drowned sister. No camera movement. Then darkness again.

THE SON. I ran over to her; I was jumping in to drag her out when I saw something that froze my blood... the boy standing stock still, with eyes like a madman's, watching his little drowned sister, in the fountain! *[The STEP-DAUGHTER bends over the basin and lowers the wrapped bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* Then... *[A revolver shot rings out from behind the fountain basin, where the chair-and-coat has been placed.]*

■ P R O J E C T I O N E N D S

The screen cuts to black on the shot. The Boy is never shown dead — only the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and what the audience has just seen for ten seconds and may not see again.

THE MOTHER *[with a cry of terror runs over in that direction together with several of the ACTORS amid general confusion].* My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

THE MANAGER *[pushing the PLAYERS aside while they lift up the chair-and-coat and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead!

THE OTHER PLAYERS. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry].* Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

THE MANAGER. Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all! I've lost a whole day over these people. A whole day.

✦
Curtain.

C O L O P H O N

Director's copy — Kiarash Jamishidi

Source: Project Gutenberg Australia, eBook No. 0608521h.html (November 2006).

This file includes the full edition notice and play text; obvious typos in the 2006 HTML were corrected when building this page.

gutenberg.net.au/ebooks06/0608521h.html